Two Days

By Aimee Bender

INTRODUCTION

As a kid, I used to believe that my opinions would never change. But as we grow older our perspectives change – perspectives about life, other people and even ourselves. Now that I'm older, I believe they'll never stop changing. Fears are diminished to be replaced by new concerns, people enter and leave our circle of importance and how we feel about ourselves are continually morphing into new perceptions. I believe that's what growing up is all about – it's all just a matter of perspective that can change over the years or in as little as Two Days by Aimee Bender.

I met Adam at the bookstore. He was in the section marked Biography/History, and he was looking at a book about some historical event no one's ever heard of. The only way I knew it was a historical event was because the cover was in black and white and had a photo on it of a tank.

I myself was aiming for art books, because my friend Terrie had just had a life-changing experience from looking at a photograph of a clown. She'd spent

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her childhood terrified of clowns, but when she saw this photo, she experienced a 180- degree shift – one of those rare moments when the other side become clear as anything and we can no longer understand why it was so hard to get before.

"Clowns are desperate," she'd told me, with wonder in her voice. "That's why they're so scary."

It hadn't occurred to me either, and I wanted to see if she was right. I too had had the experience of a childhood clown doll that one day had transformed from delightful toy-friend into the diabolical engineer of my nightmares. Someone bought it for seventy-five cents – some kid too young to feel the fear yet – and I threw the cursed coins into the outdoor trash, observing as the other neighborhood kids spotted and retrieved them. Let them spend it, I thought, from the safety of my bedroom. It will only bring them grief.

They used the quarters to buy ice cream. Story of my life.

I found the art book Terrie had been talking about and flipped toward the photo of the clown. As I

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skipped through those shiny pages, pages that smelled like a hair salon, Adam turned and held up the war book. "Do you know this photo?" he asked me, tapping the cover.

"Oh.," I said. "Is that World War I?"

He shook his head, and his hair was very light brown, almost colorless, and as it shifted, it caught no light.

"Korean War," he said. He shelved the book. "They told me it was a good read, but I just read a page and it was so dull," he said, and then he stepped closer. Aside from that colorless hair, he had a wide open face, sort of big-featured, with a big nose and big eyes and teeth. Likeable. The kind of face you could immediately trust, even against better judgment.

I was looking, at a washed-up movie star wearing sequins in some kind of aquarium tank emptied of water. I guess they were trying to work with the phrase "washed up," but the star didn't seem aware of that because she was grinning in the tank like it was all funny

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and fun. Maybe the whole book should've been titled *Desperation*.

"What are you looking at?" he asked, peering over my shoulder.

"Art photos," I said. I turned the page to have something to do, and there was the clown, with its big nose and scary mouth makeup and scary eyes and red costume. And I could see what she meant, Terri. It was trying so hard. That was part of what was so menacing, was its enormous effort to amuse. You kind of wanted to hurt the clown, before it smothered you.

"Do you think it looks desperate?" I asked him.

He squinted and stared at the photo for at least a minute. "Why do they do the eyes like that?" he said at last. "I mean, the star-shaped thing? Is that clown protocol?"

We ended up at the Greek coffee place next door, and before we left the store, I flipped through the rest of the photo book to see if the others were desperate too, but they weren't, not in the same way.

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Adam got up to get the coffees while I looked out at the cars driving by on Sunset. It was raining a little, and watching the windshield wipers made me feel more settled. The air smelled like city, like damp city. I felt attractive, talking to him. Next to those big features of his, I could feel myself as delicate. When the conversation waned, I sipped from my bitter little Greek coffee and told him that my friend Terrie was having surgery the following day. That she was young, still, but they'd found problematic shapes in her bronchitis X-ray. "Lumpy shapes," I said, "inside her lungs."

He stirred his coffee and nodded with appropriate solemnity.

"You know," I said, "I just lied. That's not true."

"About Debby?"

I reached out and touched his arm. "I didn't know what to say, so I made up Terrie's lumps. That's awful of me."

He leaned in then, and he didn't kiss me but it was too close for regular. We spent a few minutes there,

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blinking together, breathing the coffee-scented air. Who knew what would happen? He had that trust-worthy face, a face I didn't trust, simply because I'd trusted it so swiftly.

We agreed to meet the following afternoon at the beach in Santa Monica. Of course I was early because I'm always early, and I didn't head over to the water just yet, instead wandering past the snack bar, reading the names of foods listed in black plastic stick-on letters: Chili dog, Onion rings, Popsicle. Words I love to see in black plastic stick-on, words that conveyed summer to me, on this cloudy November afternoon.

I had not been flirted with in many months, and this man had not rejected the reeking desperation of either the clown or the old star, and asking for sympathy about a dying friend was the first tool that appeared from my own personal flirting toolbox. Sometimes my capacity for smallness is surprising, even to myself.

Adam was already at the beach when I walked over, and he had a picnic basket in his hands. He'd set

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up a blowzy checkered blanket, whose corners picked up with the wind, and when I walked across the sand, bumpy and difficult to traverse, he smiled at me with those wide-open eyes. For a few minutes we chitchatted, and at one point he threw his hands into the air and exclaimed some things, about nothing, really, just showing a sense of spirit. I felt the love, spreading roots in my chest, making it so easy to smile. We settled onto the blanket and he opened a small bottle of champagne and we toasted, and the water waves crashed.. I reached out a hand and touched his colorless hair, and he turned his face to my palm.

He told me he used to be a chef, that he used to won his own restaurant. He told me the name of it, and how he'd gotten a great review last year in the *LA Weekly*, saying he had a knack for unusual combinations.

"Really?" I said, impressed, and then, after a pause, he said no.

"I mean I've always liked to cook. Ever got paid for it. Sorry." We looked out at the water. It was the second lie, and it was clear, from the tone of his

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takeback, that he had surprised himself with it. For whatever reason, it seemed we couldn't help but lie to each other.

He handed me a charred chicken leg, and a bunch of grapes, and refilled my champagne. The seagulls approached. I ate the chicken and grapes, peeling stripes of chicken from the leg, but everything tasted a little off. Not like poison, but just no fulfilling, and Adam was striking me now as very difficult to know.

For dessert, he brought out oatmeal macadamia cookies that he had baked himself, but I would hardly eat them, my mouth felt so dry, and without thinking, I threw a few sprinkles to the seagulls, who stepped closer on their webbed feet. Adam and I walked to the water and held hands and touched our bare toes to the foam. I felt like crying, then, with those seagulls invading our perfect picnic behind us, eating the cookies and the chicken, stepping all over the napkins, cackling, shoving each other out of the way.

I touched his arm again, and my eyes filled with tears.

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"I know," he said. "It isn't right."

When we finally kissed, it was clear that it was our last. His lips pressed gently against mine. I felt that kind of wrenching in my heart, and as I turned and walked the other way,

A flock of seagulls. As a child, I'd found them so wonderful, seabirds, with their curving yellow-orange beaks and funny strut. They lived at the ocean, and anything that lived at the ocean I felt I could love forever. But they turned, in my mind. Sometime around adolescence, after hitting the critical mass of beach picnics, after seeing them come over again and again, pushing each other out of the way, squawking so loud, eating chicken and turkey sandwiches without pause, I found them repulsive.

At the snack bar I ordered a basket of onion rings and sat on the green-painted ocean bench, watching the water. The clouds were thick, and the water took on a metallic gray sheen that settled my mind. I have always like onion rings. They were the thickly cut kind, each ring the width of a wide plastic

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bracelet, dipped in golden brown crumbs. I ate almost the whole basket, licking the bits off my fingers, and when I was done, I threw the remaining few to the trio of waiting seagulls, who after all, were only hungry. Opinions change.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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